

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

Page 87 - Lycidas and Milton's Prose (Part 1)

Q1. What is the allegory in Milton's 'Comus' about?

- A. The fall of man
- B. Virtue attacked by sensuality and conquering by divine aid
- C. The war in heaven
- D. Political corruption in London

Answer: B

Q2. In Milton's poem 'Lycidas', what kind of Puritanism do we see?

- A. A purely theological one
- B. One that is political and ecclesiastical as well as spiritual and ethical
- C. A complete rejection of Puritanism
- D. A highly comedic one

Answer: B

Q3. Who is 'Lycidas' an elegy for?

- A. Milton's wife, Mary Powell
- B. Milton's father
- C. Milton's college friend, Edward King
- D. Oliver Cromwell

Answer: C

Q4. While the form of 'Lycidas' (pastoral elegy) belongs to the Renaissance, what does its famous attack upon the corrupt church proclaim?

- A. Milton's adherence to the Catholic faith
- B. Milton's adherence to the Puritan cause
- C. Milton's desire to become King
- D. Milton's hatred of all poetry

Answer: B

Q5. What did Milton do when he returned to England from the Continent in his 31st year?

- A. He immediately wrote Paradise Lost

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

- B. He threw himself into the fierce political and religious controversies of the hour
- C. He became an actor on the public stage
- D. He retired to the countryside to write sonnets

Answer: B

Q6. Because he gave his strength to his public duty in these controversies, what did Milton do for the next twenty years?

- A. He wrote his greatest epic poetry
- B. He turned from poetry entirely and continued active as a writer of prose
- C. He wrote romantic comedies
- D. He painted landscapes

Answer: B

Q7. How many sonnets did Milton produce during the prime of his manhood (a period equal to Shakespeare's whole dramatic career)?

- A. About a dozen
- B. 154
- C. Over 300
- D. None

Answer: A

Q8. How does the text describe Milton's prose works?

- A. They are his greatest literary achievement
- B. They are often marred by coarseness of phrase and intense bitterness of temper
- C. They are light, comedic, and highly romantic
- D. They are written entirely in Latin verse

Answer: B

Q9. What did Milton himself call his prose works?

- A. The work of his 'right hand'
- B. The work of his 'left hand'
- C. His 'crowning glory'
- D. His 'youthful folly'

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

Answer: B

Q10. Why is Milton's prose style described as heavy and cumbrous?

- A. Because he used a typewriter
- B. Because modern English prose had not yet come into existence (it featured long trailing sentences, Latin inversions)
- C. Because he did not know English well
- D. Because it was translated from French

Answer: B

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

Page 88 - Areopagitica and Paradise Lost (Part 1)

Q1. Which of Milton's prose treatises stands apart as a great and noble work that every lover of liberty should read?

- A. Paradise Lost
- B. Areopagitica
- C. Comus
- D. The Anatomy of Wit

Answer: B

Q2. What is 'Areopagitica' directed against?

- A. The monarchy
- B. An order of Parliament which established a censorship of books
- C. The Spanish Armada
- D. The theater

Answer: B

Q3. 'Areopagitica' is essentially a plea for what?

- A. Freedom of thought and speech
- B. The restoration of the King
- C. The banning of all poetry
- D. Free trade

Answer: A

Q4. When did Milton finally find the leisure to write his greatest English poem, 'Paradise Lost'?

- A. While he was at Cambridge
- B. During the height of his political power in the Commonwealth
- C. When the restoration of the monarchy drove him into private life and obscurity
- D. When he was traveling in Italy

Answer: C

Q5. The inspiration and subject-matter of 'Paradise Lost' come from what?

- A. Greek mythology

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

- B. Milton's Puritanism and theology
- C. English history
- D. Arthurian legend

Answer: B

Q6. Upon the foundation of his theology, what does 'Paradise Lost' undertake to do?

- A. 'To be or not to be'
- B. 'Assert Eternal Providence and justify the ways of God to men'
- C. 'Fools rush in where angels fear to tread'
- D. 'Make the world safe for democracy'

Answer: B

Q7. While as a thinker and moralist Milton belonged completely to Puritanism in 'Paradise Lost', to what did he belong as an artist?

- A. The Enlightenment
- B. The Renaissance (in form, style, machinery, and method)
- C. The Romantic Movement
- D. The Victorian Era

Answer: B

Q8. What were Milton's avowed models for the form and style of 'Paradise Lost'?

- A. Shakespeare's tragedies
- B. The great epics of classical antiquity
- C. French romances
- D. Medieval mystery plays

Answer: B

Q9. What fact is of capital importance when considering 'Paradise Lost'?

- A. That it was written as a comedy
- B. That it is the greatest regular epic poem in modern literature written not on a classical, but on a theological/Christian subject
- C. That it was never finished
- D. That it was written entirely in Latin

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

Answer: B

Q10. How is the combination of influences in Milton summarized in 'Paradise Lost'?

- A. A complete rejection of art in favor of religion
- B. The zeal for righteousness (Puritanism) blended with the love of learning and passion for beauty (Renaissance/Humanism)
- C. Pure science mixed with political satire
- D. A rejection of Christianity in favor of paganism

Answer: B

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

Page 89 - Milton's Later Poetry

Q1. Which of the following is NOT set forth in 'Paradise Lost'?

- A. The revolt of Satan against God
- B. The temptation of Christ in the wilderness
- C. The fall of the rebel angels
- D. The expulsion from Eden

Answer: B

Q2. What was the central purpose of 'Paradise Lost'?

- A. To prove that Satan is the true hero
- B. To show how 'man's first disobedience' brought sin and death in its train
- C. To document English political history
- D. To satirize the church

Answer: B

Q3. How does Milton choose to close 'Paradise Lost'?

- A. On a note of evil completely triumphant
- B. By prophetically introducing the divine work of redemption
- C. With the destruction of the earth
- D. With a comedic wedding

Answer: B

Q4. What sequel to 'Paradise Lost' did Milton write, covering the temptation of Christ in the wilderness?

- A. Samson Agonistes
- B. Paradise Regained
- C. Comus
- D. Lycidas

Answer: B

Q5. How do most modern readers view 'Paradise Regained' compared to its predecessor?

- A. As vastly superior
- B. As exactly equal in every way

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

- C. As a very slight thing beside its gigantic predecessor
- D. As the greatest comedy ever written

Answer: C

Q6. Which 'dramatic poem' crowns the labors of Milton's closing years?

- A. Samson Agonistes
- B. Paradise Regained
- C. Areopagitica
- D. L'Allegro

Answer: A

Q7. How is 'Samson Agonistes' fashioned?

- A. As a romantic comedy
- B. Strictly upon the principles of Greek tragedy
- C. As a sequence of sonnets
- D. As a prose novel

Answer: B

Q8. Why did Milton return to the story of Samson late in his life?

- A. He wanted to write an action play
- B. He saw in the blind, disappointed hero an image both of himself and of the overwhelmed Puritan cause
- C. Because the King ordered him to
- D. Because it was a popular trend

Answer: B

Q9. How does Milton rank among English poets?

- A. He is completely forgotten today
- B. After Shakespeare, he is the greatest English poet (the greatest outside the drama)
- C. He is considered mediocre
- D. He is only famous for his prose

Answer: B

Q10. In the judgment of critics, Milton is regarded as one of the three or four supreme poets of what?

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

- A. His local town
- B. The 17th Century
- C. The World
- D. Political satire

Answer: C

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

Page 90 - Characteristics of Milton's Poetry

Q1. Which epithet is most naturally associated with Milton's poetry?

- A. Comedic
- B. Sublime
- C. Satirical
- D. Simplistic

Answer: B

Q2. What did Matthew Arnold call the style of which Milton is our one acknowledged master?

- A. 'The grand style'
- B. 'The romantic style'
- C. 'The common style'
- D. 'The gothic style'

Answer: A

Q3. Where is Milton's astonishing descriptive power highly evident?

- A. In his sonnets about love
- B. In the scenes in Hell in the opening books of Paradise Lost
- C. In his political pamphlets
- D. In his early college poems

Answer: B

Q4. Although lacking in true dramatic sense, what does the debate in the council of fallen angels show?

- A. His hatred of politics
- B. An extraordinary insight into motive and character
- C. His ability to write comedy
- D. His ignorance of theology

Answer: B

Q5. Though an epic is theoretically impersonal, how is Milton's epic characterized?

- A. It is totally devoid of emotion
- B. It is throughout instinct with the spirit of the man himself (intense individuality)

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

- C. It feels as if a machine wrote it
- D. It focuses entirely on minor characters

Answer: B

Q6. What quote is used to describe Milton's lofty temper and passionate moral earnestness?

- A. 'A fool and his money are soon parted'
- B. 'Whose soul was like a star, and dwelt apart'
- C. 'To thine own self be true'
- D. 'All the world's a stage'

Answer: B

Q7. What form did Milton use for 'Paradise Lost' that had not previously been used for any important non-dramatic poem?

- A. Rhyme royal
- B. Spenserian stanza
- C. Blank verse (English heroic verse without rime)
- D. Free verse

Answer: C

Q8. Who remains our greatest master of English heroic verse without rime?

- A. Shakespeare
- B. Milton
- C. Marlowe
- D. Spenser

Answer: B

Q9. What does the text say about Milton's touch as a consummate literary artist?

- A. He is only good at vast general effects
- B. His touch is as sure in delicate detail as in vast general effects
- C. He struggled with small details
- D. He only cared about the plot, not the words

Answer: B

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

Q10. How is Milton's personality sometimes described despite his greatness?

- A. Warm, funny, and highly sociable
- B. Narrow, hard, and austere
- C. Completely laid-back and uncaring
- D. Always confused and uncertain

Answer: B

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

Page 91 - The Caroline Poets

Q1. Why is it difficult to establish a satisfactory order for the writers between 1625 and 1700?

- A. Because no one knows when they lived
- B. Because the Age of Milton and the Age of Dryden overlap in a broad way
- C. Because all the records were destroyed in a fire
- D. Because they all wrote anonymously

Answer: B

Q2. Under what term does the text group a number of verse writers roughly assigned to the reign of Charles I?

- A. The Elizabethan Poets
- B. The Caroline Poets
- C. The Victorian Poets
- D. The Romantic Poets

Answer: B

Q3. Did the Caroline poets stop producing work after the reign of Charles I ended?

- A. Yes, they were all executed
- B. No, many of them continued to produce through the years of the Commonwealth or even later
- C. Yes, they were exiled to France
- D. Yes, poetry was banned forever

Answer: B

Q4. What two types of poetry did the Caroline poets write?

- A. Epic and Dramatic
- B. Secular and Religious
- C. Blank verse and Free verse
- D. Political and Scientific

Answer: B

Q5. Who is considered the most important of the Caroline poets?

- A. John Milton

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

- B. Robert Herrick
- C. Ben Jonson
- D. William Shakespeare

Answer: B

Q6. What types of poetry did Robert Herrick write?

- A. Only religious hymns
- B. Both secular and religious poetry
- C. Only long epic poems
- D. Only political satires

Answer: B

Q7. Who was Robert Herrick an associate of in his early life?

- A. William Shakespeare
- B. Ben Jonson
- C. Francis Bacon
- D. Queen Elizabeth

Answer: B

Q8. What profession did Robert Herrick eventually enter?

- A. The military
- B. The law
- C. The church
- D. The theater

Answer: C

Q9. Where did Robert Herrick find himself banished to?

- A. A Devonshire parsonage
- B. America
- C. Scotland
- D. The Tower of London

Answer: A

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 18)

Q10. What is the defining characteristic used in the text to group writers as 'Caroline Poets' regardless of dates?

- A. Their political affiliation
- B. The quality of their thought and style (belonging to the older generation)
- C. Their religious denomination
- D. Their place of birth

Answer: B